the one-to-one map built by Jorge Luis Borges's imaginary empire, the Metaverse isn't an attempt to represent our world, but rather an attempt to augment or even replace our world. It doesn't offer us a digital replica of Buenos Aires or Salt Lake City; it invites people to build new virtual communities with novel landscapes and rules. As of 2024 the Metaverse seems like an overblown pipe dream, but within a couple of decades billions of people might migrate to live much of their lives in an augmented virtual reality, holding there most of their social and professional activities. People might come to build relationships, join movements, hold jobs and experience emotional ups and downs in environments made of bits rather than atoms. Perhaps only in some remote deserts, tattered fragments of the old reality could still be found, sheltering an occasional beast or beggar.

INFORMATION IN HUMAN HISTORY

Viewing information as a social nexus helps us understand many aspects of human history that confound the naive view of information as representation. It explains the historical success not only of astrology but of much more important things, like the Bible. While some may dismiss astrology as a quaint sideshow in human history, nobody can deny the central role the Bible has played. If the main job of information had been to represent reality accurately, it would have been hard to explain why the Bible became one of the most influential texts in history.

The Bible makes many serious errors in its description of both human affairs and natural processes. The book of Genesis claims that all human groups – including, for example, the San people of the Kalahari Desert and the Aborigines of Australia – descend from a single family that lived in the Middle East about four thousand years ago.[15] According to Genesis, after the Flood all Noah's descendants lived together in Mesopotamia, but following the destruction of the Tower of Babel they spread to the four corners of the Earth and became the ancestors of all living humans. In fact, the ancestors of the San people lived in Africa for hundreds of thousands of years without ever leaving the continent, and the ancestors of the Aborigines settled Australia more than fifty thousand years ago.[16] Both genetic and archaeological evidence rule out the idea that the entire ancient populations of South Africa and Australia were annihilated about four